

TECHNICAL REPORT WRITING
(TRW)
(Basics)

CHAPTER NO 4
TECHNICAL WRITING STYLE

TECHNICAL WRITING STYLE

CHAPTER IN A NUTSHELL

- WRITE CLEAR SENTENCES FOR YOUR READERS
- WRITE CLEAR PARAGRAPHS FOR YOUR READERS
 - CHOOSE A TONE FOR YOUR READERS

WRITE CLEAR SENTENCES FOR YOUR READERS

- PLACE THE SENTENCE'S MAIN IDEA FIRST
- USE NORMAL WORD ORDER
- USE THE ACTIVE VOICE
- USE PASSIVE IF AND WHEN IT IS MORE ACCURATE
- EMPLOY PARALLELISM
- WRITE SENTENCES OF 12 TO 25 WORDS
- USE 'THERE ARE' SPARINGLY
- AVOID NOMINALIZATIONS
- AVOID STRINGS OF CHOPPY SENTENCES
- AVOID WORDINESS
- AVOID REDUNDANT PHRASES
- AVOID NOUN CLUSTERS
- USE 'YOU' CORRECTLY
- AVOID SEXIST LANGUAGE AND BIAS IN LANGUAGE

How to write clear sentences?

The basic concept in technical writing is the top-down approach. We mention the most important things first (top) and then the least important things afterwards (down). The chapter discusses some 14 points in order to write clear and effective sentences.

1. Place the Sentence's Main Idea First

In every sentence, there is a subject about which the rest of the sentence gives some kind of information. If there is no subject in the sentence, it is not a sentence at all. The subject of a sentence must always be mentioned in the beginning. Doing this creates a top-down method. The audience at once knows what the sentence is about when the subject is beginning. **For example:**

The writing of manufacturing process, which explains the sequence of the production of a part and design specifications and which also details the materials needed to produce an object are two types of professional writing I will do.

(Main idea of the sentence is at the end)

Two types of professional writing that I will do are: writing manufacturing process, which explains the sequence of the production of a part and its design specifications, which details the materials needed to produce an object.

(Main idea of the sentence is at the beginning)

2. Use Normal Word Order

The normal word order in English Language is:

- 1) subject in the beginning
- 2) verb in the middle
- 3) object at the end (SVO)

(SVO: Subject, Verb, Object)

80 plus % of the written communication should be in the Normal Word Order. This itself makes the main idea to come first and sets a context for understanding.

3. Use the Active Voice

Using the active voice sets the emphasis by mentioning the subject in the beginning. This emphasizes the performer of the action rather than the object. Secondly, if a sentence contains a living person/human being /people, then it is appropriate to treat people as action initiators and not recipient of action, which can be done by the use of active voice.

4. Use Passive Voice, if and when it is more accurate.

It is more effective and accurate to use when:

- The writer wants to make the object of the sentence and not the subject appear more important.
- When you are subordinate to your reader and the reader has more power and authority than you.
- When the communication situation is negative.
- When the writer has to request for something.
- When the writer wants to appear apologetic.
- When the writer's goal is to neutralize a potentially negative reaction.
- When the writer does not intend to take explicit responsibility regarding the things being expressed.
- When the writer does not want to show confidence, appear forceful or authoritative in what is being expressed.
- When the writer wants to show importance to the reader.
- When the writer does not want to appear important but the intention is to assign importance to the point or subject matter being expressed.
- When the writer is not in control of the communication situation.

5. Employ Parallelism

Parallelism in writing means the expression of similar ideas in similar grammatical structures. A writing which observes it is comparatively easier to understand than a writing which violates it.

Example 1:

Managers guarantee that they will replace the old system and to consider the new proposal. (*Faulty parallelism*)

Managers guarantee that they will replace the old system and that they will consider the new proposal. (*Parallelism, correct*)

Example 2:

Dentists advise brushing the teeth after each meal and to avoid too much sugar in the diet. (*Faulty parallelism*)

Dentists advise brushing the teeth after each meal and avoiding too much sugar in the diet. (*Parallelism, correct*)

Example 3:

These typewriters work easily, their speed is also fine, and they create less noise while working upon them. (*Faulty parallelism*)

These typewriters work easily, speedily and noiselessly. (*Parallelism, correct*)

Example 4:

To chew carefully is as necessary for good digestion as eating slowly. (Faulty parallelism)

Chewing carefully is as necessary for digestion as eating slowly. (Parallelism, correct)

or

To chew carefully is as necessary for good digestion as to eat slowly. (Parallelism, correct)

Example 5:

This product is sturdy, light and costs very little. (Faulty parallelism)

This product is sturdy, light and cheap. (Parallelism, correct)

6. Use sentences of (12-25) words

A sentence shorter than 12 words becomes very simple becomes very childish. On the other hand, if it exceeds the count of 25 words, it becomes confusing because of its larger length and the meaning is lost till the reader reaches the end.

For example: The problem is the efficiency policy, which has measures that emphasize producing as many parts as possible, for instance, 450 parts per hour as compared to a predetermined standard usually measured by the capacity of the machine, say 500 for the rating of 90%. (40 plus words/Technically incorrect)

The problem is the efficiency policy, which calls for as many parts as possible compared to a predetermined standard. If a machine produces 450 per hour and if its capacity is 500 per hour, it has a rating of 90%.

7. Use “There are” Sparingly

Indefinite phrases like *there is, there are, there was, there were, there will be* and so on bury the subject somewhere in the middle of a sentence. It is better to avoid them because they create confusion for the audience. A sentence becomes weak in this way because the subject is not mentioned in the beginning. For example:

- 1) There is a change in efficiency policy that could increase our profits. (Ineffective)

Our profits will increase if we change our efficiency policy.

(Correct)

- 1) There is a student in the class who is not paying attention. (Incorrect)

Sohail is not paying attention in the class. (Correct)

NOTE: Sometimes in a special situation, we can use an indefinite phrase in the beginning. For example:

- 1) Three standard methods exists. (Weak)

There are three standard methods that exist. (better/strong)

8. Avoid Nominalizations

To express an action, we use verbs instead of any other part of speech. Whenever we convert verbs into nouns by adding a suffix like (*ness, ity, tion, sion, ment*), we snatch from verbs their roles of expressing action and therefore the sentence becomes weak. For example:

The training policy for most staff will have the requirement of the completion of an initial one-week seminar. (nominalized)

(Note: The portions of the words not underlined are verbs, yet we have nominalized them by adding the underlined suffixes. Nominalization is the conversion of active verbs into nouns. The verb is always a dynamic word and noun is always a static word. Verbs show action, whereas noun only name an idea or a thing)

The training policy will require most of the staff to complete a one-week seminar. (exact, perfect, more effective)

There will be costs for the installation of this machine in the laboratory of fifty thousand rupees.

We can install this machine for a cost of fifty thousand rupees in the laboratory.

We can install this machine in the laboratory for a cost of fifty thousand rupees. (exact, perfect, more effective)

9. Avoid Strings of Choppy Sentences

By virtue of the definition of a sentence, it is a complete whole or a unit in itself as regards meaningfulness. It concerns a subject, single or multiple and the rest of it called predicate, throws light on that subject. It means, the number of sentences we write, denote the units of meaningfulness we create for our readers. However, it becomes cumbersome for the imagination of the audience, if these units are in the chopped or sliced form. This simply means, that if we write a string or a group of short sentences, we are offering many small units, consisting of several subjects and their respective predicates for understanding to our readers. Hence, a string of choppy sentences should be avoided and instead more mature sentences may be created by subordinating several ideas into one sentence, thereby creating one relatively larger unit. The precaution taken while doing so is to not let such sentence exceed 25 words in consonance with point No 6 discussed in the earlier slide.

Example

These two models of Toyota and Honda are very good. Both models offer safety belts. Both models have counter balancing. Each one has SRS air bags. These features enhance safety.

Now, this is a string of choppy sentences, which is not only cumbersome, but also childish. Instead, the following sentence is better and more mature.

These two good models of Toyota and Honda offer features like safety belts, counter balancing and SRS airbags, which enhance safety.

The above sentence has broken the string of choppy sentences and now it is one whole, meaningful unit.

10. Avoid Wordiness (Adopt a way of expression, which is more precise and concise)

If something can be conveyed by the use of simple and fewer words, it should not be expressed by using difficult and more number of words.

Example:

Two important concepts that go along with this field are Inventory control and Marketing

Two important concepts in this field are Inventory control and Marketing. (Correct/better)

Example:

It is made up of very thin glass that is milky white in colour.

It is made of thin, milky white glass. (Correct/better)

Example:

The turning handle is a metal protrusion that can be easily grasped hold of by the hand to turn the gears.

The turning handle is a metal protrusion that can be easily grasped to turn the gears. (Correct/better)

11. Avoid Redundant Phrases

(Redundant: not essentially needed)

The following phrases (in the left column) should be avoided in a document and report.

Redundant (Avoid using these)

Appropriate

Due to the fact that	Because
Employed the use of	Used
Basics fundamentals	Basics or Fundamentals
Eliminate completely	Eliminate
Alternative choices	Alternatives or Choices
Actual Experience	Experience
Connected together	Connected
Final result	Result
Prove conclusively	Prove
In as few words as possible	Concisely

12. Avoid Noun Cluster

When we join two nouns, we form a compound noun that is something very normal.

On the other hand, when we join three or more than three nouns, we form a noun cluster, which should be avoided. Similarly, three word phrases should also be avoided for creating ease of understanding.

Example:

1) Allowing individual input variance of data process entry will result in higher morale in the keyboarders.

They will have higher morale, if we allow the keyboarders to enter data at their own rate. (Correct/more understandable)

13. Use “You” Correctly

The second person *you* is often used incorrectly. Whenever it is used, it must mean the audience. It should never mean the writer *or the first person ‘I’*.

For example:

I knew when I took the training course, that you must experience the problems at first. (Incorrect)

I knew when I took the training course, that I needed to experience the problems at first. (Correct)

You know when you take the training course, you will face problems in the beginning.

14. Avoid Sexist language and bias in language

Language is considered sexist when the word choice suggests only one sex even if the writer in mind means both. The language of a document should not create gender bias by mentioning males as males and females as females. If you do so, your language becomes sexist or gender-specific.

Example:

The Treasurer HITEC University must make sure that she accepts the fees without fine. (Sexist/gender-specific)

The treasurer HITEC University must make sure to accept the fees without fine. (Correct)

Each manager will direct his division's budget. (Sexist/gender-specific)

Each manager will direct the division's budget. (Correct)

Be sensitive to labels and do not write about people as if they were objects by using some terms. So, instead of writing 'complainers' or 'strikers' write, 'people who complain' and 'people, who are on strike'. In the 60s, a segment in the American population was called 'blacks' but in the 90s it changed and now they are called 'African-Americans'

Similarly, do not use language, a word or a term that equates persons with their physical condition or disability. So, instead of saying 'diabetic' it is better to write 'person with diabetes' and 'person with hypertension' instead of writing 'hypertensive'.

Write clear paragraphs for your readers

Topic sentence and coherence

The paragraph must be started with a topic sentence, which emphasizes the main idea of the whole paragraph. Then we should proceed with the top-down approach and write those sentences after the topic sentences which develop the idea contained in the topic sentence. At the third place, those sentences should be written which develop the idea contained in the secondary sentences and so on and so forth.

Repeat Terms

The important jargons should be repeated throughout the paragraph when needed. This highlights the main idea contained in the topic sentence time and again for the audience to comprehend easily and clearly.

For example:

The fly-wheel plays an important role in the working of the electric fan. The fly-wheel bears a lot of weight and therefore gathers momentum because of its weight when moved with electric power. The fly-wheel is connected with the wings and the wings also gather the same momentum as is of the fly-wheel.

(We have repeated the term Fly-wheel)

Use the dominant positions

A technical writer should prefer to mention technical terms, jargons, concepts, ideas, and phenomenon in such a way in a sentence that these are subjects of sentences. For example;

The fly-wheel is connected with the wings. (*Subject is fly-wheel*)

The wings are attached to the fly-wheel. (*Subject now is wings*)

Provide Transitions

Transitions are used for creating linkages in between sentences and also in between paragraphs sometimes.

Sequence

If we want to mention things in a sequence, then sentences may be supported by words like (*first, second, then, next*).

Addition

Sometimes when we want to add meaningfulness or information to the existing context or topic, we should use transitions like (*and, also, moreover, furthermore*)

For example:

Wind plays an important role in lifting an airplane. Furthermore, it also rushes in the engine for combustion

Contrast

If the writer wants to mention something opposite to the existing context, he should use transitions like (*but, however*)

Cause and Effect

If the writer is mentioning certain things which are going to create some results, then such a context needs to be expressed with the help of (*thus, therefore, so, hence*)

Choose a tone for the Readers

The tone is the emotional attitude of the writer towards the audience, which is established with the choice of words the writer employs.

1) Forceful tone, 2) Passive tone, 3) Personal tone, 4) Impersonal tone.

Forceful tone implies that the writer is in control of the situation, the situation is positive. It is appropriate to address subordinates or to show confidence. To make a tone passive:

- a) Use of active voice
- b) Use imperatives
- c) Do not use “weasel” words (*maybe, possibly, perhaps, hopefully, could be, could not be, can be, cannot be and so on*)
- d) Clearly indicate that you are a responsible agent

Passive tone implies that the reader has more power or that the situation is negative. It is appropriate to address a superior or to neutralize a potentially negative reaction. To make a tone passive:

- a) Use the passive voice
- b) Avoid imperatives
- c) Use “weasel” words
- d) Use longer sentences
- e) Do not take responsibility explicitly or clearly

A **personal tone** should be used for your colleagues or equals. It also shows that you have respect for the audience. Personal tone creates a certain degree of informality. To make a tone personal:

- a) Use the active voice
- b) Use first names
- c) Use personal pronouns
- d) Use short sentences
- e) Use contractions (It is = *it's*, He is = *he's*, *They are = they're etc.*)
- f) Direct questions at the readers

Impersonal tone creates a certain degree of formality. This implies that the writer is not important and the situation is neutral. To make a tone impersonal:

Do not use names, especially first names.

Do not use personal pronouns

Use the passive voice

Use longer sentences (*longer here does not mean more than 25 words*)

Example of forceful tone in writing:

I have decided to implement your suggestion to form quality circles in our organization. This proposal has great merit. You have demonstrated that we can raise morale and increase the bottom line. Make an appointment to see me in order to set up the basic planning.

Example of passive tone in writing:

The suggestion to form quality circles has not been accepted. The point of morale and bottom line benefits could possibly have other results than those indicated. Since this decision could affect the planning cycle, a meeting will be scheduled soon in order to hold a discussion on this matter.

Example of personal tone in writing:

Ahmad, thanks for that suggestion about quality circles. It's great. We all like the way it will raise morale and increase our bottom line. I'd like to see you soon on this. Would you make an appointment to see me?

Example of impersonal tone in writing:

A decision to implement the quality circles proposal has been made. This project should increase both employee morale and the profits of the organization. The following people will attend a meeting on Monday at 4:00 pm to discuss implementation of this proposal: Yasir Hussain, Nabeel Mushtaq and Khurram Mehmood.

Thank You

Happy Learning

Stay Safe!